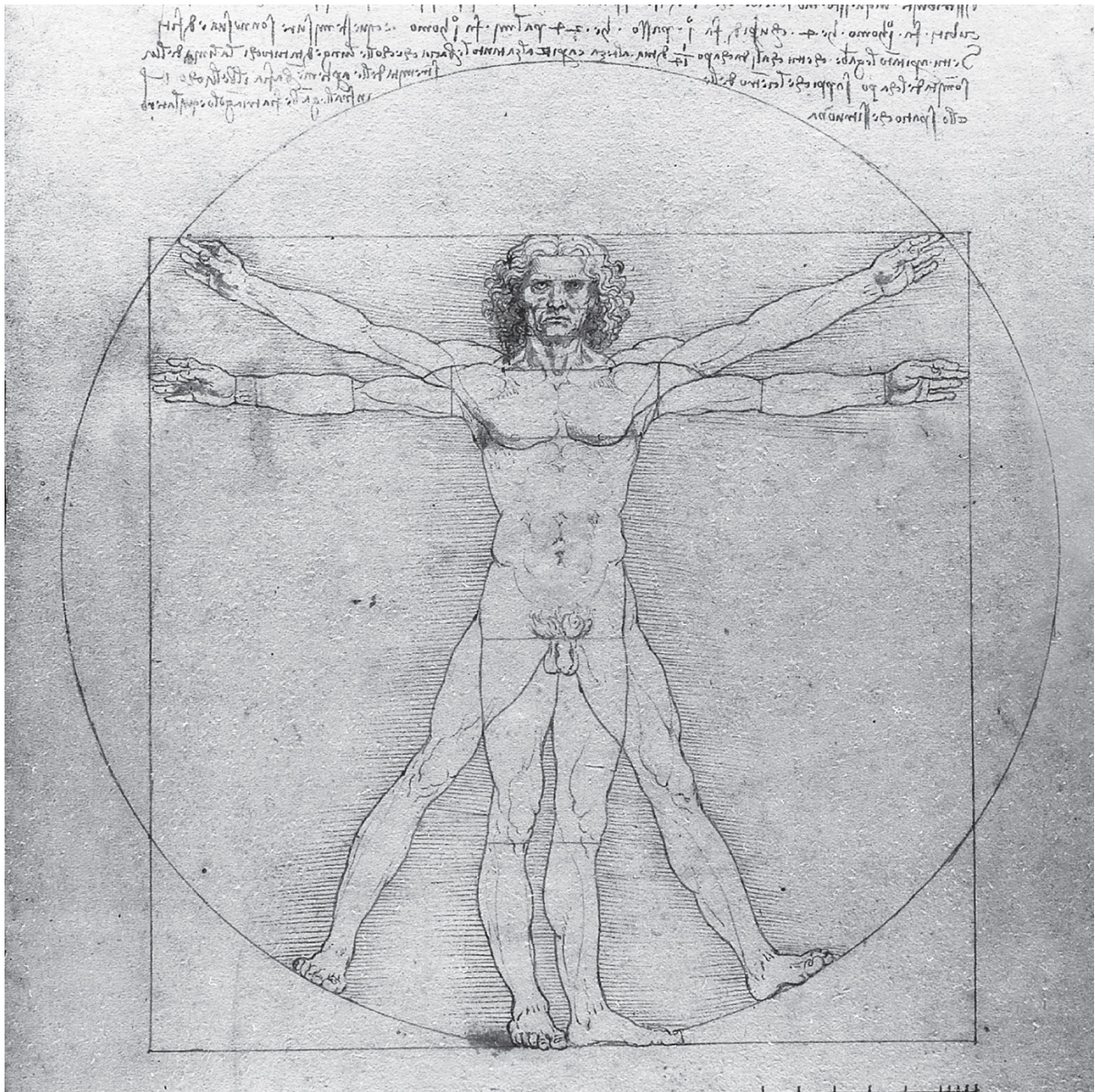


The human figure

Since ancient times, portrayals of humans have been stylized or lifelike, but always important. Venus figurines are the earliest known representations of the human body, and many cultures have modelled their deities on the human form so viewers could identify with them. In cultures where figurative art is permissible, humans have been used to relate religious stories.

The figure has also been depicted in many cultures to explore issues such as identity, gender, race and social standing, or less tangible aspects such as belonging or love. Proportion has always been subjective, but for centuries, an essential part of art students' training has been life drawing, to ensure the correct depiction of anatomy. In the late 18th century, students in the studio of Jacques-Louis David spent about six hours each day drawing from a model who remained in the same pose for a week. Ideals of beauty vary with times and individuals. For instance, Rubens's voluptuous women contrast directly with the slender figures of Amedeo Modigliani.



Leonardo, *Vitruvian Man*, c.1490